The Impact of Digital Financial Literacy on Financial Behavior among Generation Z in Sri Lanka

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ABSTRACT

Digital financial literacy (DFL) has become an essential determinant of financial decision-making in modern economies, especially with the rapid expansion of financial technologies. This study investigates the impact of digital financial literacy on household financial behavior among Generation Z in the Ratnapura District of Sri Lanka. The research adopts a quantitative approach using a structured questionnaire distributed to 379 respondents, with 146 valid responses analyzed. The study is grounded in the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), emphasizing perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use as key drivers of digital financial behavior. Data analysis was conducted using SPSS and Smart PLS, incorporating descriptive statistics, correlation analysis, and structural equation modeling (SEM). Findings reveal a strong positive relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior. Among DFL dimensions, awareness and decision-making significantly influence financial behavior, while digital knowledge, applications, and self-protection show weaker or insignificant relationships. Additionally, DFL positively impacts saving behavior, shopping behavior, and both short-term and long-term financial planning.The study contributes to existing literature by addressing a gap in Sri Lanka regarding household financial behavior and digital literacy. It provides practical implications for policymakers, financial institutions, and educators to enhance digital financial literacy among youth.

Keywords: Digital Financial Literacy, Financial Behavior, Generation Z, Sri Lanka, FinTech

1. Introduction

The rapid digitalization of financial systems has fundamentally transformed the way individuals access and manage financial services worldwide. The integration of finance with digital technologies, commonly referred to as financial technology or fintech, has facilitated the emergence of innovative platforms such as mobile banking, digital wallets, online investment systems, and real time payment infrastructures. These developments have significantly enhanced financial accessibility and efficiency, while simultaneously introducing new challenges related to digital risk, security, and financial decision making (Prete, 2021; Chandan Kumar Tiwari, 2020).

Within this evolving financial landscape, digital financial literacy (DFL) has emerged as a critical competency that enables individuals to effectively engage with digital financial services. Digital financial literacy extends beyond traditional financial literacy by incorporating digital skills, technological awareness, and the ability to evaluate and utilize digital financial tools safely and efficiently (Kass-Hanna & Lyons, 2022). It encompasses a combination of financial knowledge, digital capability, and risk awareness, which collectively influence individuals' financial decision-making processes and overall financial well-being (Lefi, 2023; Amalda Aulia et al., 2023).

The importance of digital financial literacy has been further intensified in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, which accelerated the global shift towards digital financial services. In Sri Lanka, the pandemic created conditions that necessitated the widespread adoption of digital platforms for financial transactions, including online banking, mobile payments, and e-commerce activities. This transition significantly reduced physical financial interactions and increased reliance on digital tools for everyday financial engagements (Uthaileang, 2023). Consequently, individuals' ability to navigate digital financial environments has become increasingly important for maintaining financial stability and resilience.

Financial behavior, defined as the manner in which individuals manage their financial resources through activities such as saving, spending, investing, and financial planning, plays a crucial role in determining financial well-being (Pipit Rosita Andarsari & Ningtyas, 2019). Effective financial behavior is often associated with higher levels of financial literacy, as individuals with greater knowledge and awareness are more likely to make informed and rational financial decisions (Shulin Xu, 2022). However, with the increasing digitization of financial services, traditional financial literacy alone is insufficient. Instead, digital financial literacy has become a key determinant of financial behavior in modern economies.

Generation Z, defined as individuals born between 1996 and 2010, represents a demographic group that is highly exposed to digital technologies and digital financial services (Dua, n.d.). As digital natives, they possess a natural familiarity with technological tools and platforms. Nevertheless, familiarity with technology does not necessarily translate into effective financial decision-making. The ability to utilize digital financial services responsibly depends on individuals' level of digital financial literacy, including their awareness of risks, understanding of financial products, and capacity for informed decision-making (Farida Nursjanti et al., 2023).

Despite the growing body of literature on digital financial literacy, existing research has primarily focused on its impact on financial well-being, business performance, and the adoption of financial technologies in various global contexts (Ferina Nurlaily et al., 2022; Niken Safitri et al., 2022). In Sri Lanka, empirical studies remain limited and have largely concentrated on specific populations such as undergraduates and small business owners (Dewmini et al., 2023; Dissanayake et al., 2022).

Notably, there is a lack of comprehensive research examining the relationship between digital financial literacy and household financial behavior, particularly among Generation Z.

This gap is significant, especially considering the current economic challenges faced by Sri Lanka, including inflation, financial instability, and changing consumption patterns. In such a context, understanding how digital financial literacy influences financial behavior is essential for promoting financial resilience and sustainable economic practices at the household level.

Therefore, this study aims to examine the impact of digital financial literacy on financial behavior among Generation Z in the Ratnapura District of Sri Lanka. The study focuses on key dimensions of digital financial literacy, including financial knowledge, digital knowledge, awareness, application, decision-making, and self-protection, and analyzes their influence on various aspects of financial behavior such as saving, spending, and financial planning. Furthermore, the study is grounded in the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), which provides a theoretical framework for understanding individuals' adoption and use of digital financial technologies (Davis, 1989).

By providing empirical evidence within a developing country context, this research contributes to the existing literature on digital financial literacy and offers valuable insights for policymakers, financial institutions, and educators aiming to enhance financial capability and promote responsible financial behavior in an increasingly digitalized economy.

2. Literature Review

The increasing integration of digital technologies into financial systems has significantly transformed the nature of financial engagement across both developed and developing economies. As financial services become increasingly digitized, the concept of digital financial literacy has emerged as a critical area of scholarly inquiry. Existing literature demonstrates that digital financial literacy plays an essential role in shaping financial behavior, improving financial inclusion, and enhancing economic well being. However, despite the growing attention to this concept, the literature remains fragmented, with variations in definitions, theoretical approaches, and empirical findings. This chapter provides a critical synthesis of existing studies on digital financial literacy and financial behavior, while identifying key theoretical and empirical gaps relevant to the present study .

2.1 Conceptual Foundations of Digital Financial Literacy

Digital financial literacy has been conceptualized as an extension of traditional financial literacy that incorporates digital competencies required for engaging with modern financial systems. Kass Hanna and Lyons (2022) define digital financial literacy as a combination of knowledge, awareness, and skills necessary to effectively use digital financial services. Similarly, Lefi (2023) emphasizes the role of digital technologies in facilitating financial management through platforms such as mobile banking and electronic payment systems.

Although these definitions highlight the multidimensional nature of digital financial literacy, the literature lacks conceptual consistency. Some studies focus primarily on technical skills, while others emphasize financial knowledge or behavioral aspects (Akhtar, 2021). This inconsistency creates challenges in comparing empirical findings and limits the development of a unified theoretical framework. Furthermore, many studies implicitly assume that access to digital financial tools leads to improved financial literacy. This assumption overlooks the complexity of financial decision making, as individuals may use digital platforms without fully understanding financial risks or implications. Amalda Aulia et al. (2023) argue that digital financial literacy must encompass not only access and usage but also critical evaluation and risk awareness.

Therefore, digital financial literacy should be understood as a holistic construct that integrates financial knowledge, digital capability, awareness, and behavioral competence. This broader perspective is essential for capturing the true impact of digital financial literacy on financial behavior.

2.3 Financial Behavior and Its Determinants

Financial behavior refers to the actions and decisions individuals make in managing their financial resources, including saving, spending, investing, and planning. According to Pipit Rosita Andarsari and Ningtyas (2019), effective financial behavior involves responsible budgeting, prioritization of needs, and long term financial planning. Traditional economic theories assume that individuals behave rationally when making financial decisions. However, behavioral research suggests that financial decisions are influenced by cognitive limitations, social factors, and access to information.

Empirical studies consistently indicate that financial literacy positively influences financial behavior, particularly in terms of saving and investment decisions (Shulin Xu, 2022). However, the increasing reliance on digital financial systems introduces additional complexities. Individuals must possess not only financial knowledge but also the ability to navigate digital platforms and assess associated risks.

A critical limitation in existing literature is the tendency to treat financial behavior as a single construct. In reality, financial behavior is multidimensional and includes both short term and long term decision making processes. For instance, spending behavior may be influenced by immediate needs, while saving and investment decisions reflect long term financial planning. Studies that fail to distinguish these dimensions risk oversimplifying the relationship between literacy and behavior. The present study addresses this limitation by examining multiple dimensions of financial behavior, including saving behavior, shopping behavior, and financial planning .

2.3 Theoretical Perspective: Technology Acceptance Model

The Technology Acceptance Model introduced by Davis (1989) provides a widely accepted theoretical framework for understanding the adoption of digital technologies. The model posits that perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use are the primary determinants of individuals' intention to adopt technological systems.

In the context of digital financial literacy, the Technology Acceptance Model offers valuable insights into how individuals engage with digital financial services. Individuals with higher levels of digital financial literacy are more likely to perceive digital financial tools as useful and easy to use, thereby increasing their likelihood of adoption (Angeles, 2022). This relationship highlights the importance of digital competencies in facilitating the effective use of financial technologies.

However, the model has been criticized for its limited consideration of external factors such as socio economic conditions, cultural influences, and risk perceptions. In developing economies such as Sri Lanka, these contextual factors play a significant role in shaping financial behavior. Therefore, while the Technology Acceptance Model provides a useful theoretical foundation, it should be interpreted within a broader socio economic context to fully explain digital financial behavior.

2.4 Empirical Evidence from Global Studies

A substantial body of international research has examined the relationship between digital financial literacy and financial outcomes. Ferina Nurlaily et al. (2022) found that digital financial literacy has a significant positive impact on personal financial health, particularly during periods of economic uncertainty. Similarly, Amalda Aulia et al. (2023) demonstrated that digital financial literacy improves financial well being, with financial behavior acting as an important mediating factor.

Research focusing on specific populations reveals important variations in digital financial literacy levels. Guangshun et al. (2024) found that rural populations exhibit lower levels of digital financial literacy, particularly in areas such as risk awareness and consumer protection. This highlights the existence of a digital divide between different socio economic groups. Farida Nursjanti et al. (2023) also reported that digital financial literacy among Generation Z varies significantly based on demographic characteristics such as education and income.

Despite these contributions, global studies exhibit several limitations. Many studies focus on specific sectors such as small and medium enterprises, limiting their applicability to household level financial behavior. In addition, there is a heavy reliance on quantitative methods, which often fail to capture the underlying behavioral mechanisms influencing financial decisions. Furthermore, most studies are conducted in developed or emerging economies, which may not reflect the conditions of developing countries with different institutional and economic structures.

2.5 Empirical Evidence in the Sri Lankan Context

In the Sri Lankan context, research on digital financial literacy is relatively limited and remains in its early stages. Existing studies primarily focus on business performance and specific demographic groups. Ranatunga et al. (2020) found that digital literacy reduces business uncertainty and enhances economic performance among small enterprises. Similarly, Dissanayake et al. (2022) reported that digital financial literacy positively influences entrepreneurial performance.

Dewmini et al. (2023) examined the relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior among university students and found a significant positive association. However, this study is limited to an educated population, which may not represent the broader population. As a result, its findings cannot be generalized to households or other demographic groups.

A critical gap in the Sri Lankan literature is the lack of studies examining household financial behavior in relation to digital financial literacy. This gap is particularly significant given the recent economic challenges faced by the country, including inflation and financial instability. Understanding how digital financial literacy influences financial behavior at the household level is essential for developing effective financial policies and interventions.

2.6 Research Gap and Contribution

The review of existing literature reveals several important gaps. There is a lack of conceptual clarity regarding digital financial literacy, as definitions vary across studies. Empirically, there is limited research examining the relationship between digital financial literacy and household financial behavior. In addition, there is a lack of studies conducted in developing countries, particularly in the Sri Lankan context. Furthermore, existing research does not adequately address generational differences, especially among Generation Z.

This study addresses these gaps by examining the impact of digital financial literacy on household financial behavior among Generation Z in Sri Lanka. By incorporating multiple dimensions of digital financial literacy and financial behavior, the study provides a comprehensive analysis that contributes to both theoretical and empirical literature .

This section critically reviewed the literature on digital financial literacy and financial behavior, highlighting key concepts, theoretical perspectives, and empirical findings. While existing studies confirm the importance of digital financial literacy, they also reveal significant limitations in terms of conceptual consistency, contextual relevance, and population coverage. The present study builds upon these insights to provide a more comprehensive understanding of the relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior in a developing country context.

3. Methodology

This study adopts a quantitative research design within a positivist paradigm to examine the relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior among Generation Z in Sri Lanka. A deductive approach is employed, drawing on the Technology Acceptance Model to test hypothesized relationships between constructs (Davis, 1989). The use of a quantitative method enables objective measurement and statistical analysis of relationships between variables.

Data were collected using a structured questionnaire administered online. The instrument consisted of thirty seven items designed to measure digital financial literacy and financial behavior, along with demographic characteristics. The target population comprised individuals belonging to Generation Z in the Ratnapura District, selected due to its socio economic diversity. Based on standard sampling guidelines, a sample size of 379 was determined; however, 146 valid responses were obtained and used for analysis . A simple random sampling technique was applied to enhance representativeness.

Digital financial literacy was operationalized as a multidimensional construct consisting of financial knowledge, digital knowledge, awareness, application, decision making, and self protection. Financial behavior was measured through saving behavior, shopping behavior, short term planning, and long term planning. All constructs were assessed using a five point Likert scale, ensuring consistency with prior studies.

Data analysis was conducted using Statistical Package for Social Sciences and Smart Partial Least Squares software. Descriptive statistics were used to summarize the data, while Pearson correlation analysis examined relationships between variables. Structural Equation Modeling using Partial Least Squares was employed to assess both measurement and structural models. Reliability was evaluated using Cronbach alpha and composite reliability, while validity was assessed through average variance extracted and heterotrait monotrait ratio. Structural relationships were tested using bootstrapping, with significance determined at p values less than 0.05.

Ethical standards were maintained by ensuring voluntary participation, anonymity, and confidentiality of respondents. Although the cross sectional design limits causal inference, the methodology provides a robust framework for examining the relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior in a developing country context.

4. Results and Discussion

4.1 Results

The empirical findings provide strong support for the relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior among Generation Z respondents.

Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 presents the descriptive statistics of the main variables. The mean value of digital financial literacy is 3.636, indicating that respondents generally possess a moderate to high level of digital financial literacy. Financial behavior records a mean value of 3.530, suggesting that respondents demonstrate relatively positive financial practices. The standard deviations indicate moderate variability in responses .

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics

Variable	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
Digital Financial Literacy	146	1.86	5.00	3.636	0.795
Financial Behavior	146	1.68	4.68	3.530	0.525

Correlation Analysis

Table 2 presents the Pearson correlation results. A positive and moderately strong relationship is observed between digital financial literacy and financial behavior ($r = 0.681$), indicating that higher levels of digital financial literacy are associated with improved financial behavior.

Table 2: Correlation Matrix

Variables	Digital Financial Literacy	Financial Behavior
Digital Financial Literacy	1.000	0.681**
Financial Behavior	0.681**	1.000

Note: $p < 0.01$

Structural Model Results

The structural model results are presented in Table 3. Digital financial literacy has a strong and statistically significant impact on financial behavior ($\beta = 0.709$, $p < 0.05$). The t statistic of 13.680 confirms the robustness of this relationship. The R^2 value of 0.503 indicates that digital financial literacy explains approximately 50.3 percent of the variance in financial behavior.

Table 3: Structural Model Results

Relationship	Beta (β)	T value	P value	R^2	Decision
DFL → Financial Behavior	0.709	13.680	0.000	0.503	Supported

Dimensions of Digital Financial Literacy

Table 4 presents the results for individual dimensions of digital financial literacy. Among the dimensions, awareness and decision making show statistically significant relationships with financial behavior. Other dimensions do not demonstrate significant effects.

Table 4: Effects of DFL Dimensions on Financial Behavior

Variable	Beta	T value	P value	Decision
Financial Knowledge	0.034	0.193	0.847	Not Supported
Digital Knowledge	0.100	0.997	0.319	Not Supported
Applications	-0.007	0.099	0.921	Not Supported
Awareness	0.349	2.969	0.003	Supported
Decision Making	0.301	1.975	0.048	Supported
Self Protection	0.093	0.636	0.525	Not Supported

Impact on Financial Behavior Dimensions

Table 5 summarizes the impact of digital financial literacy on different components of financial behavior. All relationships are positive and statistically significant.

Table 5: Impact of DFL on Financial Behavior Dimensions

Relationship	Beta	T value	P value	Decision
DFL → Saving Behavior	0.224	6.226	0.000	Supported
DFL → Shopping Behavior	0.057	2.151	0.031	Supported
DFL → Long Term Planning	0.343	12.010	0.000	Supported
DFL → Short Term Planning	0.410	9.367	0.000	Supported

4.2 Discussion

The results confirm that digital financial literacy has a strong and statistically significant influence on financial behavior. The moderate to high mean values indicate that respondents possess relatively good levels of both digital financial literacy and financial behavior. The correlation and structural model results consistently demonstrate a positive relationship, supporting the argument that digital competencies play a crucial role in shaping financial decision making.

A key finding of this study is that awareness and decision making are the only dimensions of digital financial literacy that significantly influence financial behavior. This suggests that practical understanding and the ability to make informed decisions are more important than simply possessing knowledge or technical skills. This finding is consistent with behavioral perspectives, which emphasize that knowledge must be translated into action to influence outcomes (Amalda Aulia et al., 2023).

The lack of significance for financial knowledge and digital knowledge highlights a critical limitation in traditional financial education approaches, which often focus on knowledge acquisition rather than behavioral application. This indicates that improving awareness and decision making skills may be more effective in promoting positive financial behavior.

The positive impact of digital financial literacy on saving behavior, shopping behavior, and financial planning further emphasizes its importance. The strong influence on long term and short term planning suggests that digitally literate individuals are more likely to engage in structured financial management. This is particularly relevant in the context of economic uncertainty, where effective financial planning is essential.

Overall, the findings support the theoretical assumptions of the Technology Acceptance Model, suggesting that individuals with higher digital financial literacy are more likely to adopt and effectively use digital financial services. However, the results also indicate that behavioral and contextual factors should be considered alongside technological factors to fully understand financial behavior.

5. Conclusion and Recommendations

5.1 Conclusion

This study examined the impact of digital financial literacy on financial behavior among Generation Z in the Ratnapura District of Sri Lanka. The findings provide strong empirical evidence that digital financial literacy is a significant determinant of financial behavior. The results indicate a positive and statistically significant relationship between digital financial literacy and financial behavior, suggesting that individuals with higher levels of digital financial literacy are more likely to demonstrate responsible financial practices.

The study further reveals that digital financial literacy contributes substantially to financial behavior, explaining a considerable proportion of its variation. Among the dimensions of digital financial literacy, awareness and decision making emerge as the most influential factors, while financial knowledge, digital knowledge, application, and self protection do not show significant effects. This highlights the importance of practical understanding and the ability to make informed financial decisions, rather than merely possessing theoretical knowledge or technical skills.

In addition, the analysis demonstrates that digital financial literacy positively influences key aspects of financial behavior, including saving behavior, shopping behavior, and both short term and long term financial planning. The strong impact on financial planning indicates that digitally literate individuals are better equipped to manage their finances strategically and prepare for future financial needs.

Overall, the study contributes to the existing literature by providing empirical evidence on the relationship between digital financial literacy and household financial behavior in a developing country context. It addresses a significant research gap by focusing on Generation Z and by examining financial behavior at the household level, which has been largely overlooked in prior studies.

5.2 Recommendations

Based on the findings of this study, several practical recommendations can be proposed for policymakers, financial institutions, and educators.

First, financial literacy programs should move beyond traditional knowledge based approaches and focus on enhancing awareness and decision making skills. Since these dimensions have the most significant impact on financial behavior, educational initiatives should incorporate practical training, real life scenarios, and interactive learning methods that enable individuals to apply financial knowledge effectively.

Second, policymakers should prioritize the development of national strategies to improve digital financial literacy, particularly among young individuals. This can be achieved through integrating digital financial education into school and university curricula, as well as through public awareness campaigns that promote the responsible use of digital financial services.

Third, financial institutions should play an active role in improving digital financial literacy by providing user friendly platforms, educational resources, and guidance on digital financial products. Simplifying digital interfaces and increasing transparency can enhance users' understanding and encourage more effective financial decision making.

Fourth, targeted interventions should be designed to address gaps in awareness and decision making among specific demographic groups. Given the diversity within Generation Z, customized programs that consider socio economic and regional differences may be more effective in improving financial outcomes.

Finally, future research should explore additional factors that may influence financial behavior, such as psychological, social, and cultural variables. Longitudinal studies could also be conducted to examine how digital financial literacy and financial behavior evolve over time.

In an increasingly digitalized financial environment, digital financial literacy is no longer optional but essential. Enhancing digital financial literacy can empower individuals to make informed financial decisions, improve financial well being, and contribute to overall economic stability. Therefore, fostering digital financial literacy should be considered a key priority for sustainable financial development in Sri Lanka.

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